

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 179

By Sparks

A RESOLUTION to recognize the mental health consequences of social media on K-12 students.

WHEREAS, the mental health crisis among young people has reached alarming levels, with rising rates of anxiety, depression, and self-harm, particularly since the early 2010s; and

WHEREAS, Jonathan Haidt's *The Anxious Generation* identifies key contributors: the proliferation of smartphones and social media, the decline of unstructured play, and the rise of overprotective parenting; policymakers have a crucial role in reversing these trends by implementing regulations and policies that support healthier childhood development; and

WHEREAS, research shows a strong correlation between excessive screen time and declining mental health in adolescents, and social media platforms use engagement-driven algorithms that expose youth to harmful content, fostering anxiety and depression; and

WHEREAS, policymakers should enact laws and regulations that: (1) set age restrictions on social media use, similar to existing regulations for tobacco and alcohol; (2) require social media companies to provide age-appropriate settings and limit algorithm-driven content for minors; and (3) introduce digital well-being curricula in schools to educate youth on healthy technology habits; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Haidt's work also recognizes that free play is essential for building resilience, social skills, and emotional intelligence, yet it has drastically declined due to over-scheduling and safety concerns, and overregulation of play spaces and excessive adult intervention limit children's opportunities for real-world learning; and

WHEREAS, policymakers at both the state and local levels should: (1) reassess and reduce unnecessary regulations on play spaces to encourage more free play in communities; (2) incentivize schools and municipalities to create play-friendly environments, including outdoor

recess requirements; and (3) promote awareness campaigns on the benefits of independent play for children's development; and

WHEREAS, additionally, excessive risk aversion in parenting has led to children lacking autonomy and problem-solving skills, and overregulation and parental fears limit youth opportunities for independence and decision-making; and

WHEREAS, state lawmakers should: (1) support parental education programs that encourage age-appropriate independence; (2) encourage "Let Grow" initiatives that promote walking to school, outdoor play, and self-directed activities; and (3) reform liability laws that discourage schools and communities from allowing free play; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we recognize the mental health consequences of social media on K-12 students and support efforts to address this issue in the State of Tennessee.